

By Abhijit Dasgupta

Jyoti Basu is dead, long live Jyoti Basu. And, in West Bengal, every effort is being made by some CPI(M) leaders as well as others out to make a fast buck by clinging on to the legacy of the man and, in the process, reaping a rich harvest. You name it and somebody in Bengal is planning something to keep him alive somehow. From the rural entertainment opera known as jatra to films to statues to naming islands after Basu, the roster seems never-ending. The CPI(M), as a political entity, does not endorse this deification but it's not saying a vehement no either. As jatra organiser Tapas Das of Anjali Opera confirms, "After the first show, which was a runaway hit, we have decided to get ministers from all parties together and organise a show. I am sure they will love it."

Jatra as an entertainment form is as old as the hills in Bengal, and is particularly popular in the villages where people flock from neighbouring hamlets to watch a popular jatra which is like an opera held on an open-air dais with viewers sitting all around. A popular jatra does not only carry by word of mouth but is attended at least by 1,000 people per show. The jatra on Basu, the first show of which was held on March 14 after only a dozen rehearsals, at Arambagh's Khanakul village, a favourite haunt of Mamata Banerjee, drew crowds in by the thousands and carried on for three hours flat without a single interval. Not one soul stirred during the show which ended at midnight. Says Das, "When we planned the show, called *Alor Shikha, Amar Jyoti*, loosely translated into the "Undying Spirit: Jyoti Basu" with that extra, unavoidable

The Deification of JYOTI BABU

From statues to operas and films, the Jyoti Basu hagiography becomes a cultural obsession



GAURISHANKER PANDE (LEFT)
AS JYOTI BASU IN THE SHOW

Photographs by SUVASHIS MULLICK/www.indiatodayimages.com

pun on light and *jyoti*, we knew we had a hit on our hands. But the sort of response we got during the first show was quite unbelievable."

Das, however, said that the intent was not deification. "No, far from it. It just needed to be done. The fact that Basu died in January only gave

us cause to do it now. It should have been done long back." Das also said that none of the CPI(M) ministers or top leaders had been invited for the first show though the Zila Parishad, controlled by the CPI(M), was out in full strength. The man who played Basu, an actor called Gaurishanker Pande, does not resemble Basu in any way but he carried the role with panache. "In jatra, all you need to be is loud. That was a challenge. Basu was anything but loud. I heard his speeches over and over again on tapes and saw him on video. It was difficult to talk like him. Those short sentences com-



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TAPAS DAS, Anjali Opera